What has caused the current cold peace in South Asia? Three factors can be identified. First, the military regime of General Musharraf, dependent on American largesse, was loath to initiate yet another crisis with India. Such a reckless endeavor could easily undermine the invaluable U.S.-Pakistan relationship. Second, India's willingness to resort to coercive diplomacy had exacted a significant material price on Pakistan.[12] Consequently, it would have been unwise to precipitate another crisis. Third and finally, the shift from a BJP-dominated regime to a Congress-led regime in 2004 opened up the possibility of a more conciliatory relationship. That said, this cold peace may not have ensued were it not for the restraint that nuclear weapons had induced in the 2001–2002 crisis. Though both sides had come perilously close to war during that protracted confrontation, in the end nuclear weapons had been a vital force for mutual, and especially Indian, restraint. Forging such a strategy has not proven to be easy because of the low threshold that Pakistan has publicly set for a resort to nuclear weapons in the event of a conventional conflict with India. Still, Indian military planners believe that it is possible to do so.

What does the future hold for Indo-Pakistani relations? What role are nuclear weapons likely to play in this relationship? The evolution of the relationship is likely to depend on several factors operating at global and regional levels. At a global level, critical choices on the part of the United States can have an important impact on the Indo-Pakistani relationship. If the United States continues with its policy of "dehyphenation" and treats India and Pakistan as distinct entities, it could play a salutary role in the region.[13] This policy will entail dealing with significantly different issues in the two states while working on some common concerns. In Pakistan, the United States should concentrate on bolstering the current and future civilian regimes, concomitantly reducing the overweening presence and role of the military and inducing it to eschew the pursuit of jihadi terror as an instrument of its security policy and direct its assistance toward the reform of Pakistan's social and economic sectors. In dealing with India, the United States should offer continuing support for the country's fitful efforts toward economic liberalization, urge it to improve the efficacy of its internal security apparatus, and encourage